

| Assessment | Test                | Domain                       | Skill                      | Difficulty                                          |
|------------|---------------------|------------------------------|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| SAT        | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Form, Structure, and Sense | Medium <div><div></div><div></div><div></div></div> |

Question

French philosopher René Descartes doubted whether he could prove his own existence. Eventually, he found proof in his famous phrase “I think, therefore I am.” The \_\_\_\_\_ complexity: only those who exist would be able to ponder their existence.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. phrases’ simplicity masks its
- B. phrases simplicity masks their
- C. phrase’s simplicity masks their
- D. phrase’s simplicity masks its

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The conventions being tested are the use of possessive nouns and the use of possessive determiners. The singular possessive noun "phrase's" correctly indicates that there is only one simple phrase. The singular possessive determiner "its" agrees in number with the singular possessive noun "phrase's," reinforcing the idea that there is only one simple yet complex phrase.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "phrase's," not the plural possessive noun "phrases'." Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "phrase's" and the corresponding singular possessive determiner "its," not the plural noun "phrases" and the corresponding plural possessive determiner "their." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive determiner "its," not the plural possessive determiner "their."